



FROM DAWN TO AFTER DARK

PRAYERS FOR EVERY HOUR

Love like a Mother
by Elizabeth Berget

A PRAYER FOR WAKING UP (TOO EARLY)

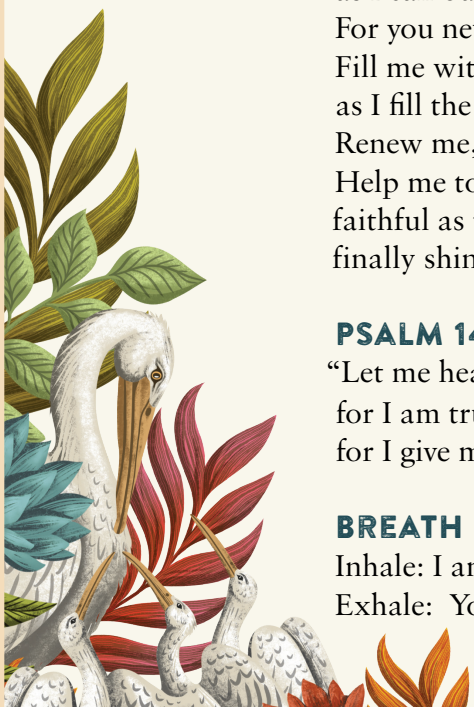
Oh God whose mercies are renewed with each sunrise,
it is still dark outside,
and my persistent widows
are already padding down the hall
in footie pajamas,
Soon they will be at my bedside —
asking for cereal,
asking for milk,
asking for help putting on the Spiderman costume —
I hear their echoes in the boat,
as your friends woke you up,
asking for your help
before your eyes were even open;
Oh Lifter of my Head,
lift my head from this pillow,
Animate these dry bones
right out of this bed,
Open my tired eyes
to see you in their need,
Let me hear your loving kindness
in the voices of my children
still sticky with sleep,
as they call out to me,
as I call out to you —
For you never fail to rise when I call,
Fill me with strength for the day
as I fill the cups and bottles for breakfast,
Renew me, once again,
Help me to rise with your mercy -
faithful as the sun's rays
finally shining through the curtains.

PSALM 143:8

“Let me hear of your unfailing love each morning,
for I am trusting you. Show me where to walk,
for I give myself to you.” (NLT)

BREATH PRAYER:

Inhale: I am tired and weary.
Exhale: You are the lifter of my head.





A PRAYER FOR BREAKFAST, LUNCH, DINNER, OR SNACKTIME

Good Giver God,
You who came to us in our hunger -
Mercy steeped in milk and honey -
leaving us a trail of manna in the wilderness
to follow you as you
bake up our daily bread,
inviting us to take and eat,
find me here amidst the crumbs and cut-up grapes,
alongside sticky high chairs
and backseat snacks on the drive home from school,
in between stirring the soup and the sink full of dishes;
Satisfy me with your abundance,
Set a table before me in the presence of my fears,
as I lay down the plates and forks and cups,
Oh Bread of Life,
take the loaves and fishes of my efforts,
and let me eat the feast of your sufficiency,
with leftovers to spare.

JOHN 6:35

Jesus said to them, "I am the bread of life. Whoever comes to me will never be hungry, and whoever believes in me will never be thirsty." (NRSVUE)

BREATH PRAYER:

Inhale: They need so much of me.
Exhale: You are my Provider.



A PRAYER FOR THE MOMENTS IN BETWEEN



God of mustard seeds and sparrows,
Incarnate God,
who came to be with us,
who came to be us,
who scraped your knees and took naps and outgrew your clothes,
May I see you anew in the margins —
When I am pushing my laughing child on the swing,
 Let me know that you delight in my delight,
When I am searching for a missing baseball glove,
 Let me remember your search for lost lambs,
When I am pushing the stroller up a grueling hill,
 Let me recognize your strength in my weakness,
When I am reading the same board book for the eleventh time,
 Let me realize you are the Truest Story,
When I am filling out the family calendar,
 Let me know you have ordered my days since before I was born,
When I am snuggling the baby against my chest,
 Let me sense your surrounding presence,
When I am doing the dishes,
 Let me rejoice in how you are restoring every wrong,
When I am navigating a toddler tantrum,
 Let me feel your steady arms around my own unraveling,
When I have heard “Mom!” called for the fifty-seventh time in one hour,
 Let me rest in knowing that you never tire of my cries for help —
May I devour your broken bread each day,
Let your cup meet my parched lips at night,
Move my feet to the rhythm of the song of the birds of the air,
Overwhelm me with the aroma of each resplendent lily in the field,
Let me recognize you in the least of these moments.

ACTS 17:27-28

“Starting from scratch, he made the entire human race and made the earth hospitable, with plenty of time and space for living so we could seek after God, and not just grope around in the dark but actually find him. He doesn’t play hide-and-seek with us. He’s not remote; he’s near. We live and move in him, can’t get away from him!” (The Message)

BREATH PRAYER:

Inhale: I feel far from you.

Exhale: You are closer than this breath.





A PRAYER FOR THE WITCHING HOUR

Oh God,
in whom all things are held together,
hold me together
in this hour of ungluing,
I am swirling in a cyclone of need —
the pot needs to be stirred,
the baby needs to be held,
the toddler needs a snack,
the nine-year-old needs help with math,
the teenager needs a ride —
And me?

I need a break —
As the sun sinks toward this day's end,
I am overwhelmed
(and understaffed),
Oh God of interruptions and hem tugs,
of baskets of bread from almost nothing and
healing from your own two hands,
Out of your overflow of abundance,
meet me in the scarcity of my own sufficiency.

HEBREWS 4:16

“Let us therefore approach the throne of grace
with boldness, so that we may receive mercy and
find grace to help in time of need.” (NRSVUE)

BREATH PRAYER:

Inhale: I am empty.
Exhale: Fill me with your strength.





A PRAYER FOR BATHTIME

God of dirty feet —
of basins and suds and towels —
who bent and knelt
to scrub the dirt from between your disciples' toes,
I am bending over this bathtub,
kneeling on the soaked floor,
to wash the dirt of this day
off the child before me,
My hand slips through the bubbles and toy boats,
the sharks,
the dinosaurs,
and rubber ducks,
to wash each wrinkled finger and pruny toe,
to gently rinse the shampoo away from worried eyes,
as I
clean,
restore,
refresh,
As I run the warm water,
Will you cleanse me of the sin that clings to me?
Will you wash me whiter than snow
and baptize me with tender care?
Will you turn the ritualistic waters of my own efforts
into the rich, red wine of your renewal?
As I wrap my child in the warmth of a soft towel,
will you wrap me in your restoration?
Will you meet me here amidst the splashing and suds and
clean me,
restore me,
refresh me?

TITUS 3:5B

"He saved us through the washing of rebirth
and renewal by the Holy Spirit." (NIV)

BREATH PRAYER:

Inhale: I feel like a mess.

Exhale: You restore my soul.



A PRAYER FOR BEDTIME



God of green pastures and still waters,
Gentle Shepherd,
who carries the weary lambs in your arms,
Carry me now as my arms grow heavy
from holding my own little lamb,
by the dim glow of the nightlight,
for what feels like a million hours,
as I endlessly
bounce and sway,
rock and sing,
hug and hold,
willing this child to sleep —
Open my eyes in this sacred darkness
to how I refuse your rest,
to how my endless efforts and expectations
have walked me into this Valley of Exhaustion,
Even here,
as I drag myself along,
You invite me to stop —
You comfort me,
You restore my soul,
Let me close my eyes
as you remove my hard and heavy yoke
and draw me into the softness of your lap —
God of rest,
let me stop resisting.

MATTHEW 11:28-30

“Come to me, all you who are weary and are carrying heavy burdens, and I will give you rest. Take my yoke upon you, and learn from me, for I am gentle and humble in heart, and you will find rest for your souls. For my yoke is easy, and my burden is light.” (NRSVUE)

BREATH PRAYER:

Inhale: I cannot keep going.
Exhale: You offer rest and restoration.





A PRAYER FOR WAKING IN THE MIDDLE OF THE NIGHT

Oh God who never slumbers or sleeps,
How I wish it were that easy!
My eyes feel gritty,
every heavy limb aches
to stay in this warm bed,
and I'm afraid to look at the clock,
but the cries over the monitor
overpower every other instinct —
I come when my children cry —
In the night,
my shuffled footsteps
echo the Shepherd's as he
searched for the bleating lost lamb,
My outstretched arms reach for my child in the dark,
Are these not yours on the cross?
You come when your children cry —
And there in the quiet dark,
the two of us,
No! the three of us,
find one another —
*I comfort because you comfort,
I soothe because you soothe,
I come because you come.*



PSALM 145:18

“The Lord is near to all who call on him,
to all who call on him in truth.” (NRSVUE)

BREATH PRAYER:

Inhale: I cry out to you.

Exhale: You come to me, every time.